

Conflict and Peace

Week 3: Ethnic and Political Origins of Conflicts

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How do institutional backgrounds shape conflicts?

Institutional backgrounds can interact with economic factors that affect conflicts

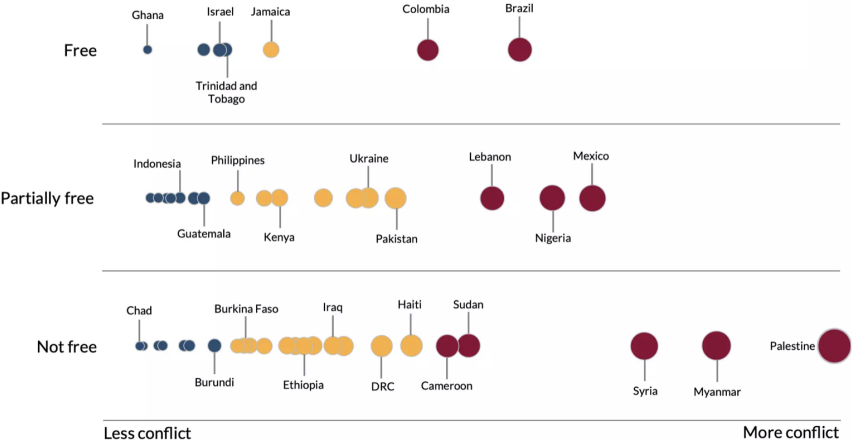
- Democracies can hold decisionmakers accountable
- Transparency reduces uncertainties and misperceptions
- Cohesive institutions can defuse conflict by bridging different groups/stakeholders

Yet, there are many cases where institutions can foster conflict

- Many states are still autocratic
- Many democracies are also experiencing surge of extremist movements
- Media are often misused as tools of propaganda and misinformation, not transparency
- Leads to difficulty in fostering cohesion: Cultural and ethnic wars on the rise

Conflict across countries with different political spectrum

Top 50 Conflict Index country rankings by freedom status



Index level

- Extreme
- High
- Turbulent

Source for freedom status: Freedom House

Political motives and violence



Opposition supporters burn a banner during violent protests in Nairobi, Kenya following a disputed election that gave a second presidential term to Mwai Kibaki (31 December 2007). Gallo Images/Reuters/Afolabi Sotunde

Where we are at

Need to understand institutions and economics behind conflicts

- Context-by-context: Fractionalized and polarized ethnicities, religion
- Attempt to understand what institutional backgrounds shapes economic motives
- Possible with innovative research design based on new numerical, satellite, text data

We explore the cultural origins of war: Ethnicity, colonialism, religion etc

We also look at how political motives shape wars: Propaganda, misinformation, strategic moves for political gain in elections etc.

Roadmap for today

1. Overview of the topic

2. Institutional and cultural origins of conflict

- 2.1 Esteban, Mayoral, and Ray (2012): Ethnicity and Conflict: an Empirical Study
- 2.2 Bonomi, Gennaioli, Tabellini (2021): Identity, Beliefs, and Political Conflict
- 2.3 Michalopoulos, Papaioannou (2016): The Long-Run Effects of the Scramble for Africa
- 2.4 Bonnier, Poulsen, Rogall, Stryjan (2020): Preparing for Genocide: Quasi-experimental Evidence from Rwanda [student presentation]

3. Political motivations behind conflicts

- 3.1 Yanagizawa-Drott (2014): Propaganda and Conflict: Evidence from Rwandan Genocide
- 3.2 Condra, Long, Shaver, Wright (2018): The Logic of Insurgent Electoral Violence
- 3.3 Dube, Naidu (2015): Bases, Bullets, and Ballots: The Effect of US Military Aid on Political Conflict in Colombia [student presentation]

Esteban, Mayoral, and Ray (2012):
Ethnicity and Conflict: an Empirical Study

Q: How do ethnic divisions affect conflict?

Are there meaningful relationship between ethnic division and social conflict?

- Early on: Income and wealth distribution → conflict?
 - ▶ Poor antagonistic to the rich
- Lacked explanation on how this sentiment channels into organized action
- Start looking into different markers: Identities, ethnicities, religions etc

This paper extends the explanation of sources of conflicts beyond economic factors

- In particular, focuses on how fractionalized the society is along ethnic lines
- Provides definition of ethnic division and how each relate to conflicts
- Heterogeneities depending on conflict over public goods and private goods
 - ▶ Public: Benefits independent of group size, but depends on identity (ethnic dominance)
 - ▶ Private goods: Benefits decrease with group size, but identity does not matter (resources)
- Empirically demonstrates their finding at a country level data

Setting up the ethnic conflict model

Setup: Total of m groups within a society in conflict over public and private goods

- Group i has N_i people (Total population: N), with n_i share of population
- Each individual exerts effort r , with cost of that effort being $c(r)$
- Each group exerts R_i effort, with probability of winning being $p_i = \frac{R_i}{R_1 + \dots + R_N}$
- Private goods of μ and public good of π at stake (per capita)

What are the payoffs of conflict for group i ?

- Private goods are divided among same groups
- If group i 's desired public good chosen, πu_{ij} , otherwise incurs cost $\pi(u_{ii} - u_{ij}) = \pi d_{ij}$

$$\underbrace{\pi u_{ij} - \sum_{j=1}^m p_j \pi d_{ij}}_{\text{Net gains of public good } j \text{ chosen for } i} + \underbrace{p_i \frac{\mu}{n_i}}_{\text{Gains from private good}} - \underbrace{c(r)}_{\text{cost of effort}}$$

Definition of indices of ethnic division

Different types of measures

- Polarization: Emphasis of number *and symmetry in distribution* of groups in conflict

$$P = \sum_{i=1}^m \sum_{j=1}^m n_i^2 n_j d_{ij}$$

- Greenberg-Gini Index: Emphasis on the number of groups in conflict

$$G = \sum_{i=1}^m \sum_{j=1}^m n_i n_j d_{ij}$$

- Fractionalization: Generalized G to case where $d_{ii} = 0$ and $d_{ij} = 1$ for $j \neq i$

$$F = \sum_{i=1}^m n_i (1 - n_i)$$

Hypotheses and data

Hypotheses

- Public goods: Polarization increases conflicts (symmetric groups $\rightarrow$ contention $\uparrow$)
- Private goods: Fractionalization increases conflict (Division of limited goods)
- Group cohesion (low G/N , groups per capita) increases conflict (easier mobilization)

Dataset

- Conflicts: UCDP/PRIO dataset
- Definition of groups: Ethnolinguistic dataset from Fearon (2003), among others
- Also control for GDP, population, resources (oil), terrains, democracy, past conflict
- Runs OLS to map correlation between conflict and indices

$$Y_{it} = \alpha + \beta_1 P + \beta_2 F + \beta_3 (G/N) + \gamma X_{it} + e_{it}$$

Baseline findings

TABLE 1—BASELINE SPECIFICATION WITH PRIO25, FEARON GROUPINGS

Variable	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)	(7)
<i>P</i>	7.73*** (0.005)	6.07*** (0.002)	6.90*** (0.000)	6.96*** (0.001)	7.38*** (0.001)	7.39*** (0.001)	6.50*** (0.004)
<i>F</i>	2.59*** (0.000)	1.86*** (0.000)	1.13** (0.029)	1.09** (0.042)	1.30** (0.012)	1.30** (0.012)	1.25** (0.020)
<i>G/N</i>	-6.95* (0.067)	-5.47** (0.011)	-4.37* (0.077)	-4.45* (0.071)	-4.77* (0.072)	-4.80* (0.068)	-5.09* (0.074)

- p-values in parenthesis
- Polarization explains conflicts far more than Fractionalization
- Group cohesion (smaller *G/N*) increases conflicts

Graphical findings

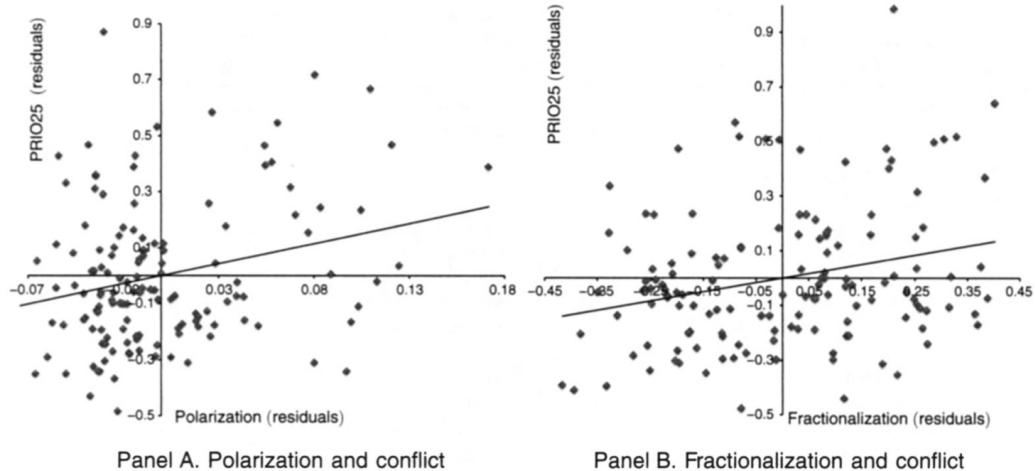


FIGURE 1. POLARIZATION, FRACTIONALIZATION, AND CONFLICT

Discussion and takeaways

Takeaways

- Each conflict contains fight for private and public goods
- Polarization explains the incidence of conflicts, especially those with public nature
- Fractionalization explains conflicts too, albeit with limited scope
- Group cohesion increases conflicts

Limits and going forward

- Empirically separating private and public component: Not mutually exclusive
- Applicable to other divides: Religion, caste, language etc

Bonomi, Gennaioli, Tabellini (2021):
Identity, Beliefs, and Political Conflict

Q: How does identity affect behavior of groups in conflict

Increasing salience of conflicts over identity and culture

- Conflict (not necessarily violent) over immigration, race, and ethnicity on the rise
 - ▶ Preference for redistribution increasingly correlated with progressive cultural policy
- Growing partisanship and hatred towards outsiders
- While mostly confined to politics, it can extend to violent conflicts

This paper models how identity becomes important in forming beliefs

- Cultural conflict $\uparrow \rightarrow$ salience of identity $\uparrow \rightarrow$ Belief on group-linked stereotypes $\uparrow$
- If culture becomes more relevant for welfare, it becomes key determinant of identity
- Similar if economic shocks affects cultural groups differently (globalization)
- Increased belief distortions leading to rise of ingroup vs outgroup conflict

Model of identity and political conflict

Setup of policies and voters

- Policy 1: Proportional income tax τ that finances public good, but has distortion $-\frac{\varphi}{2}\tau^2$
- Policy 2: Cultural policy q (race, immigration) where $q \uparrow \rightarrow$ more liberal stance
- Voters are defined by relative income ϵ and cultural trait ψ (mean 0, st.dev 1)
 - ▶ Higher ϵ : Relatively wealthy; Higher ψ : Prefer progressive values
 - ▶ ρ captures correlation between ϵ and ψ : We assume non-negative correlation
- Public goods have marginal value ν , and ψ types value it additionally by β

Policy preference is the sum of expected income, public goods, and cultural policy

$$W^{\epsilon\psi}(\tau, q) = \underbrace{(1 + \epsilon)(1 - \tau) - \frac{\varphi}{2}\tau^2}_{\text{Income net of taxes and distortions}} + \underbrace{(\nu + \beta\psi)\tau}_{\text{Value of public goods to } \psi} - \underbrace{\frac{\kappa}{2}(q - \psi)^2}_{\text{preference on } q, \text{ weighed by } \kappa}$$

Optimal policy preference

How do voters evaluate policies?

$$W^{\epsilon\psi}(\tau, q) = \underbrace{(1 + \epsilon)(1 - \tau) - \frac{\varphi}{2}\tau^2}_{\text{Income net of taxes and distortions}} + \underbrace{(\nu + \beta\psi)\tau}_{\text{Value of public goods to } \psi} - \underbrace{\frac{\kappa}{2}(q - \psi)^2}_{\text{preference on } q, \text{ weighed by } \kappa}$$

- The optimal individual (involves calculus) and social (plug in mean values) policies are
 - ▶ Individual: $\tau = \frac{(\nu + \beta\psi) - (1 + \epsilon)}{\varphi}$, $q = \psi$; Social: $\tau = \frac{\nu - 1}{\varphi}$, $q = 0$
 - ▶ More progressive ($\psi \uparrow$): More redistribution and more liberal; Richer ($\epsilon \uparrow$): Less tax
 - ▶ Social optimum reflects average income and identities

Identities change, especially if only one categorization defines an identity

- Categories: Wealth (poor or rich) and culture (progressive or conservative)
- Identity is set to maximize similarities within groups and conflicts between groups
- Culture matters with high κ , inter-cultural differences, and ρ

How changes in identity affects policy preferences?

Changes in salience of identities distort beliefs that decide preferences for τ and q

- Belief: One's perceived future income and cultural trait relative to real mean values

$$\epsilon_G^\theta = \epsilon + \theta(\bar{\epsilon}_G - \bar{\epsilon}_{\text{not } G}), \quad \psi_G^\theta = \psi + \theta(\bar{\psi}_G - \bar{\psi}_{\text{not } G})$$

- Distortion comes from perceived differences between in-group and out-groups

Distortion of beliefs $\rightarrow$ Distortion of preferred policies

- Poor and conservative voter: Demand for redistribution $\uparrow$ ($\tau \uparrow$) & Liberal policy $\downarrow$ ($q \downarrow$)
- Salience of conservatism $\uparrow$ ($\psi \downarrow$) $\rightarrow$ preference for $q \downarrow$ & $\tau \downarrow$
 - ▶ Salience of culture over income decreases concerns about being poor (more optimistic ϵ)
- This could be triggered by shocks irrelevant to redistribution (e.g. migrant inflow)
- Explain why some group of voters change parties entirely
 - ▶ Conservative and poor voters: Left-wing (class salient) $\rightarrow$ Right-wing (culture salient)

Salience of immigration shifted policy preferences

Salience of immigration $\uparrow$ (early 2010s) $\rightarrow$ Shift policy preferences across different groups

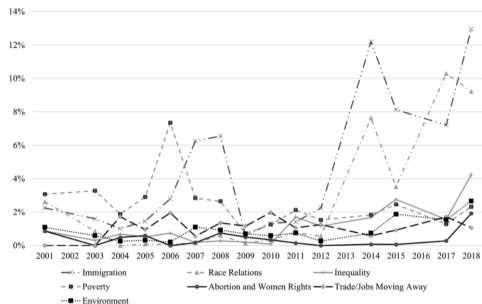
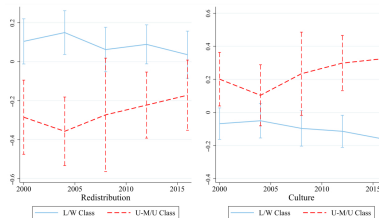
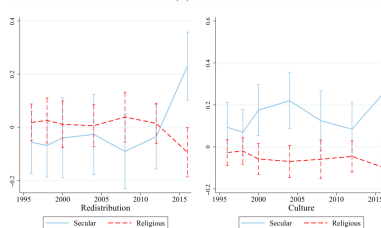


FIGURE II
Most Important Problem Facing the Country

(a) Salience of issues over time



(A) Class



(B) Religiosity

(b) Group conflict over time

Discussion and takeaways

Takeaways from the paper

- Voters decide based on the perspective of the most salient group (income vs culture)
- Changes in salience of certain groups → Changes in preferred policies
- These could change what is being contested in politics (and beyond)

Potential extensions

- Changes in salience of identity explains economic outcomes
 - ▶ How does migration affect tax preferences?
(Alesina, Miano, Stantcheva 2023, to be covered later in course)
- Violent conflicts could explained by this framework
 - ▶ If what is at stake is resources and vengeance, conflicts can happen with wars
- Potential implications for understanding modern party politics

Michalopoulos, Papaiaonnou (2016): The Long-Run Effects of the Scramble for Africa

Q: How does colonial border design affect conflict and development?

Long-lasting consequences of colonial institutions

- Extractive institutions → long-run impacts on economic & human capital development
- Less highlighted: Design of arbitrary borders without local knowledge
 - ▶ Territorial borders became strict (not the case before)
 - ▶ Many ethnic groups were split to multiple countries
 - ▶ Many countries ended up with multiple ethnic groups

This paper analyzes the long-run impact of such colonial institution

- Compare partitioned ethnic groups to non-split groups
- Do they have different characteristics (geography, pre-colonial economics etc)?
- Are partitioned groups susceptible to conflicts? What about economic development?

Scramble for Africa

Timeline

- 1860s: French and British enter West Africa under agreement on areas of influence
- More Europeans enter → Divide unexplored areas (e.g. 1885 Berlin Conference)
- Inadequate local knowledge (no African representatives)

Who are the partitioned ethnic groups?

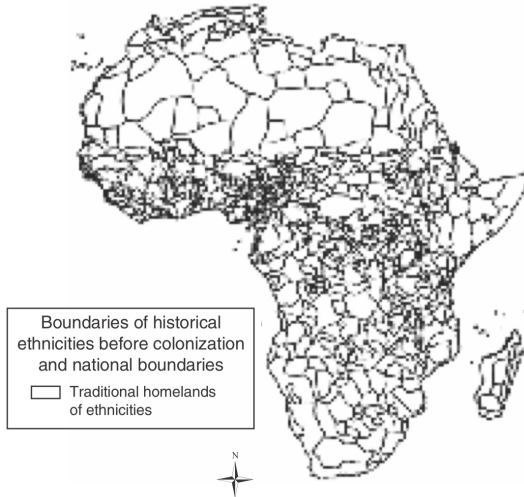
- Ethnicities with 10%+ of their surface belonging to multiple countries
- 229 ethnicities (27.7% of sample)

How partitioning can affect conflicts and development

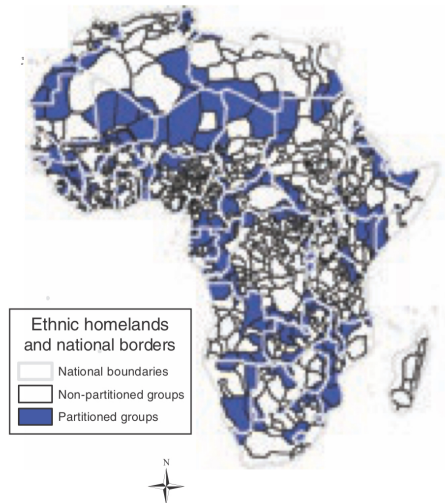
- Secessionism: 20% of African civil wars involve secessionist component
- Repression: Ethnicity-based discrimination on economic and social activities
- Spillover: Population displacement → Ethnic component change in neighbors

Scramble for Africa

Panel A



Panel B



Data and empirical strategy

Data Sources

- Ethnic distribution: Ethnolinguistic map (George Peter Murdock, 1959)
- Geography: 2000 Digital Chart of the World
- Conflict: ACLED, UCDP dataset
- Individual-level outcomes: Demographic and Health Surveys

Empirical strategies compare partitioned ethnic groups to non-partitioned ones

$$\text{Conflict: } y_{ec} = \alpha_c + \gamma \text{SPLIT}_{ec} + \phi \text{SPIL}_{ec} + \delta X_{ec} + e_{ec}$$

$$\text{Indiv: } y_{ierc} = \alpha_c + \beta \text{SPLIT}_e + \delta X_{ierc} + \psi Z_{irc} + u_{ierc}$$

- Control for fraction of partitioned adjacent groups in country c SPIL_{ec}
- Land and individual characteristics controlled for
- For comparability, partitioned and non-partitioned groups need similar characteristics (Only land mass differs)

More conflicts in partitioned groups

TABLE 3—ETHNIC PARTITIONING AND CIVIL CONFLICT INTENSITY:
BASELINE COUNTRY FIXED EFFECTS ESTIMATES

	All ethnicity-country homelands				Ethnicity-country homelands close to the national border			
	Deadly incidents NB-ML (1)	Deadly incidents indicator LPM (2)	Total casualties NB-ML (3)	Duration all incidents Poisson-ML (4)	Deadly incidents NB-ML (5)	Deadly incidents indicator LPM (6)	Total casualties NB-ML (7)	Duration all incidents Poisson-ML (8)
SPLIT (partitioning) double-clustered SE	0.3356 (0.1357)	0.0599 (0.0287)	0.4843 (0.1651)	0.2015 (0.0622)	0.4651 (0.2037)	0.0820 (0.0428)	0.8489 (0.3787)	0.2784 (0.1216)
SPIL (adjacent split) double-clustered SE	0.3948 (0.2465)	0.1461 (0.0463)	0.1161 (0.3121)	0.2478 (0.1174)	0.2745 (0.3110)	0.2378 (0.0611)	0.3573 (0.5155)	0.3731 (0.1804)
log likelihood	-2,910.906	—	-4,516.44	-2,759.21	-1,028.82	—	-1,657.27	-1,057.16
Adjusted R^2	—	0.411	—	—	—	0.449	—	—
Simple controls	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Location controls	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Geographic controls	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Country fixed effects	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Observations	1,212	1,212	1,199	1,212	579	579	575	579

Partitioned groups experience more discrimination

TABLE 7—ETHNIC PARTITIONING AND POLITICAL VIOLENCE (*Discrimination and Ethnic Wars*)

	Ethnic war			Ethnic discrimination			Violence	
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)	(7)	(8)
SPLIT (partitioning)	0.1155 (0.0509)	0.1402 (0.0381)	0.1101 (0.0390)	0.1030 (0.0342)	0.0778 (0.0276)	0.0718 (0.0282)	0.6175 (0.2663)	0.5802 (0.2565)
SPIL (adjacent split)			0.2570 (0.1155)			0.0203 (0.0759)		1.1716 (0.6170)
Adjusted R^2	0.019	0.423	0.487	0.018	0.475	0.521	—	—
log likelihood	—	—	—	—	—	—	−422.612	−417.453
Observations	593	593	593	593	593	593	593	593
Country fixed effects	No	Yes	Yes	No	Yes	Yes	No	No
Simple controls	No	No	Yes	No	No	Yes	Yes	Yes
Location controls	No	No	Yes	No	No	Yes	Yes	Yes
Geographic controls	No	No	Yes	No	No	Yes	Yes	Yes

Individuals from partitioned groups are worse-off

TABLE 8—THE LONG-RUN EFFECTS OF ETHNIC PARTITIONING ON INDIVIDUAL WELL-BEING AND EDUCATION:
DHS DATA

	All observations			Border observations		
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
<i>Panel A. Dependent variable composite wealth index</i>						
Partitioning-identity	−0.3853	−0.2369	−0.2069	−0.2818	−0.2557	−0.2454
double-clustered SE	(0.1129)	(0.0972)	(0.0905)	(0.1018)	(0.0810)	(0.0789)
Nonindigenous	0.1936	0.1873	0.1890	0.1359	0.1792	0.1828
double-clustered SE	(0.0887)	(0.0744)	(0.0721)	(0.0783)	(0.0767)	(0.0750)
Adjusted R^2	0.028	0.145	0.171	0.053	0.134	0.162
Observations	88,171	88,171	88,171	44,090	44,090	44,090
<i>Panel B. Dependent variable education</i>						
Partitioning-identity	−0.9907	−0.6594	−0.4897	−0.5301	−0.4701	−0.4089
double-clustered SE	(0.4045)	(0.3045)	(0.2520)	(0.3086)	(0.2658)	(0.2444)
Nonindigenous	0.3116	0.2922	0.3163	0.1273	0.2028	0.2056
double-clustered SE	(0.2695)	(0.2485)	(0.2328)	(0.2043)	(0.1829)	(0.1693)
Adjusted R^2	0.176	0.227	0.281	0.164	0.198	0.244
Observations	88,043	88,043	88,043	44,030	44,030	44,030
Country fixed effects	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Location controls	No	Yes	Yes	No	Yes	Yes
Individual controls	No	No	Yes	No	No	Yes

Discussion and Takeaways

Arbitrarily drawn borders → conflict

- Neighboring countries support co-ethnics on other side of border
- State-driven conflicts against rebels (of different ethnicities)
- Political discrimination: Increase participation in ethnic-based civil wars

It also hurts individual well-being

- Fewer assets owned, poor access to public goods, less education
- Not explained by split country contexts, but due to split ethnicity

Bonnier, Poulsen, Rogall, Stryjan (2020):
Preparing for Genocide: Quasi-experimental
Evidence from Rwanda [student presentation]

Yanagizawa-Drott (2014):
Propaganda and Conflict: Evidence from
Rwandan Genocide

Q: What roles do mass media play in conflict and violence?

What drives participation into political mass violence?

- Usually sponsored by elites with agendas to eliminate groups considered threatening
- Reportedly used mass media to justify and induce citizen participation
 - ▶ Nazis in WW2: Joseph Goebbels as propaganda minister
 - ▶ Russia's state-controlled media in its invasion of Ukraine
- So how does these propaganda work?

This paper uses radio campaigns during Rwandan Genocide to answer this question

- Violence by military, local militias, and ordinary civilians against non-ruling ethnicity
- Investigates the mechanism of direct persuasion and local spillovers
 - ▶ Direct persuasion: Convince listeners directly
 - ▶ Local spillovers: Spread info and belief via social networks

History of Rwandan Genocide

Rwandan Genocide in early 1990s

- Hutus majority and Tutsi minority clashed since 1973
- After assassination of Hutu president (Apr. 1994), extremists began ethnic cleansing
- State-sponsored militias and civilian-led violence ensued
- Wave of genocides ended in July 1994: 500,000 Tutsis killed

How was mass media utilized

- Inflammatory messages by RTLM: Run by an extremist Hutu faction (Hutu Power)
- Called for extermination of Tutsis
 - ▶ Justified genocide for “self-defense” against Tutsis
 - ▶ Referred to Tutsis as cockroaches
 - ▶ Claimed that Hutus engaged in killings would not be held accountable

Conceptual frameworks and mechanisms

Direct Effects

- Exposure to media alters behavior by affecting beliefs and preferences
- Listeners consider RTLM messages as credible: even moderate Hutus were killed
- But participation in violence is costly: so was RTLM messages persuasive enough?

Spillover Effects

- Social interactions can augment influence of media Exposure
- Word-of-mouth to nonlisteners, peer pressure, lower cost via collective action
- Countervailing effect: Free-rider problem can co-exist in theory

How to distinguish these mechanisms

- Direct effect: Only consider own location
- Spillover: Also consider characteristics of neighboring villages

Data and empirical strategy

Sources of key variables

- Violence data from court records (Gacaca courts)
- Village-level radio data from Bureau of Information and Broadcasting
- Topography data from Shuttle Radar Topography Mission dataset

Empirical strategy leverages strength of transmission predicted by topography

- i.e. Presence of hills, which is not correlated with other factors affecting conflict
- Direct and spillovers estimated as follows

$$\text{Direct: } y_{vci} = \beta_v r_{ci} + \pi X_{ci} + \gamma_c + e_{civ}$$

$$\text{Spillover: } y_{vci} = \lambda_{vd} \bar{r}_{dci} + \phi_d \bar{X}_{dci} + \gamma_c + e_{ci}$$

where $\bar{r}$ captures average coverage within d km from village i in commune c

Distribution of violence and radio

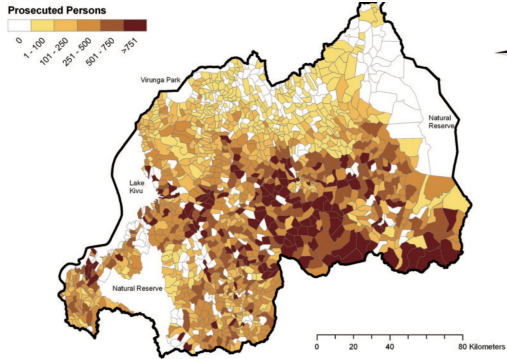


FIGURE I
Genocide Violence in Villages

(a) Violence distribution

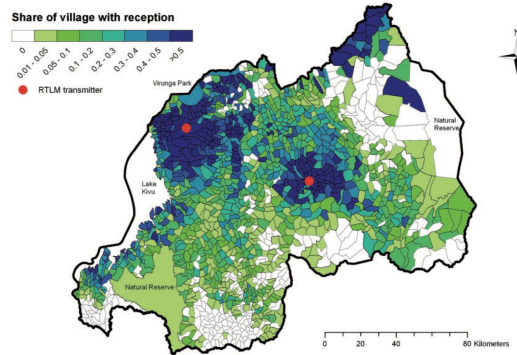


FIGURE II
RTLM Radio Coverage

(b) Radio distribution

Direct effects: Organized violence increases significantly

(4)	(5)	(6)	(7)	(8)	(9)
Dependent variable: log(prosecuted persons)					
Militia violence			Individual violence		
0.582** (0.239)	0.559*** (0.216)	0.544*** (0.206)	0.450* (0.233)	0.465* (0.252)	0.418* (0.246)
		0.589*** (0.171)			0.624*** (0.150)
		0.004 (0.101)			-0.015 (0.069)
		-0.233 (0.149)			0.113 (0.152)
		-0.245*** (0.090)			-0.193** (0.075)
		0.030 (0.126)			0.186* (0.103)
		0.098 (0.092)			0.014 (0.084)
		0.041 (0.092)			0.079 (0.068)
		-0.028 (0.101)			-0.012 (0.077)
1065	1065	1065	1065	1065	1065
0.52	0.53	0.55	0.62	0.63	0.65
Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y
N	Y	Y	N	Y	Y

Spillovers larger than direct effects

	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
	Dep. var.: log(prosecuted persons)					
	Militia violence			Individual violence		
Radio coverage in nearby villages, within 10 km	2.18*** (0.797)	2.04*** (0.771)	1.76** (0.760)	0.468 (0.570)	0.348 (0.572)	0.682 (0.588)
Radio coverage in nearby villages, within 10–20 km	−0.341 (0.739)	−0.277 (0.763)	−0.163 (0.821)	−0.223 (0.675)	−0.167 (0.721)	−0.303 (0.751)
Radio coverage in village		0.505** (0.199)	0.198 (0.443)		0.437* (0.249)	0.801 (0.551)
Radio in village * Radio in nearby villages, within 10 km			0.841 (1.029)			−0.999 (0.971)
Observations	1065	1065	1065	1065	1065	1065
R-squared	0.56	0.56	0.56	0.65	0.65	0.65
Commune FE	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y
Propagation controls	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y
Propagation controls, nearby villages	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y
Additional controls	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y

Takeaways and discussion

Direct effect <<<< Spillover

- Militia presence in *neighboring* villages increased significantly
- Social interactions do augment influence of direct exposure to media
- Thus, violence begets violence

Implications

- Need further studies on what type of social interactions matter
 - ▶ Collective action change cost-benefit analysis? Social pressure to conform?
- Dangers of mass media that promotes inflammatory messages
 - ▶ Not just violence, but any type of misinformation could have wide-ranging effects

Condra, Long, Shaver, Wright (2018)
The Logic of Insurgent Electoral Violence

Q: How are politically-motivated attacks designed?

Does elections promote peace or trigger violence?

- Reduce incentives for rebellion and symbolizes state-building and consolidation
- Attacks often committed around elections by entities trying to undermine the state
- Implications for efforts to promote free and fair elections in post-conflict societies

This paper demonstrates logics of insurgents in electoral violence

- Opportunity to undermine legitimacy of the formal government
- Also cautious enough to minimize civilian targets (sustain civilian support to attackers)
- Leverages variation in timing and location of violence around election periods
 - ▶ Attack earlier in the day than usual?
 - ▶ Damage select routes that voters use to go to polls

Background and framework

Afghanistan in 2001-2017 (before Taliban re-takeover)

- Elections in '04(Pr), '05(Pa), '09(Pr), '10(Pa), '14(Pr)
- Taliban actively tried to undermine legitimacy of the Afghan government
 - ▶ Targeted candidates, poll booths, security forces, and voters around elections
 - ▶ Qualitative evidence that they calibrated attacks to avoid excessive civilian harm

Framework: Competitive governance between insurgents and the state

- Insurgents benefit from violence directed against government
- But it is undermined if civilians are attacked and consequently oppose insurgents
- Electoral violence: Target state legitimacy vs. Harmful when civilians are attacked

Claims to be tested in this paper

- Insurgents time attacks during elections to damage state legitimacy
- Select location and timing strategically: Use IEDs on key routes and early hours

Data and empirical strategy

Data Sources

- Attacks ('03-'15): International Security Assistance Force (ISAF)
- Combined with survey data, population data, voting records, and road network maps

Empirical strategy leverages timing and location of attacks in election vs. non-election days

- Timing: $A_{d_i} = \xi + \sum_{i=1(\neq 13)}^{24} \theta_i \text{hour}_{d_i} + \sum_{i=1(\neq 13)}^{24} \alpha_i (\text{hour}_{d_i} \times \text{election}_d) + \psi_d + e_{d_i}$
- Location: $Y_r = \alpha + \beta_1(\text{Route}_r) + \beta_2(\text{Violence}_{rw}) + \beta_3 X_r + e_r$

Then, the paper estimates the effect of these violence on voting behaviors (IV)

- Morning attacks: $Y_{de} = \alpha + \beta_1 \widehat{\text{Attacks}}_{det} + \beta_2 X_{de} + e_{de}$
 - ▶ IV: average of wind conditions in 10:30PM (day before)-4:30AM and 4:30AM-10:30AM
- Location effects: $Y_r = \alpha + \beta_1 \widehat{\text{IED}}_r + \beta_2 \text{violence}_{rw} + \beta_3 X_r + e_r$
 - ▶ IV: Nighttime cloud cover (high cover $\rightarrow$ hard to detect $\rightarrow$ more attack)

Rise of early-morning attacks, but not targeting civilians

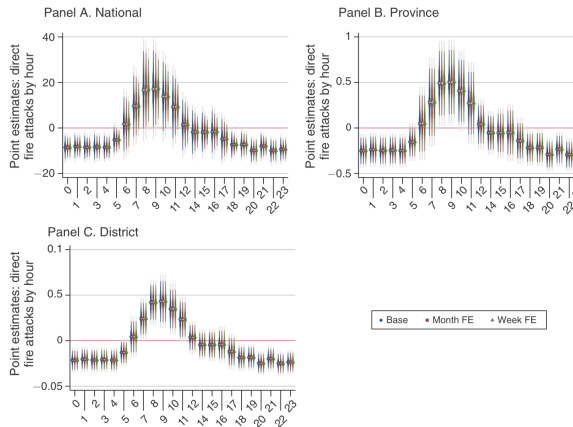


FIGURE 4. DIRECT FIRE ATTACKS BY HOUR, ELECTION DAY VERSUS NON-ELECTION DAY USING 90-DAY WINDOW (National, Province, District)

(a) Timing of all attacks

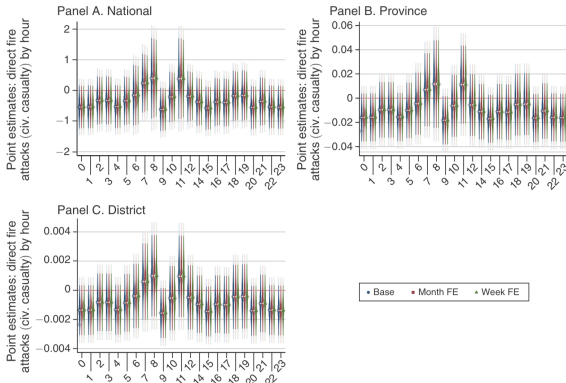


FIGURE 5. DIRECT FIRE ATTACKS CAUSING CIVILIAN CASUALTIES BY HOUR, ELECTION DAY VERSUS NON-ELECTION DAY USING 90-DAY WINDOW (National, Province, District)

(b) Timing of attacks causing civilian casualties

Rise of IEDs at key roads and population centers, but not more intense

TABLE 1—IED DEPLOYMENT ALONG THE AFGHAN ROAD NETWORK AHEAD OF THE 2014 ELECTION

	Deployment (1)	Deployment (2)	Count (3)	Deployment (4)	Deployment (5)
Election-day route	0.00474 (0.00112) [0.00161]	0.00391 (0.00113) [0.00154]	−0.00101 (0.00248) [0.00290]		
Pashtun population (10k)				0.0251 (0.00920) [0.00996]	0.0286 (0.00929) [0.0101]
Observations	72,862	72,862	72,862	15,761	15,761
Clusters	4,577	4,577	4,577	3,805	3,805

Notes: The outcome of interest varies. In columns 1, 2, 4, and 5, the outcome is a binary indicator of IED deployment along the road during the preelection period (March 1 until April 4, 2014). In column 3, the outcome is the count of IEDs deployed along the road during the preelection period. All models include district fixed effects (except column 1), and control for road length and a six-month pretrend in IED deployment. Heteroskedasticity robust standard errors are reported in parentheses; standard errors clustered by polling center catchment areas are reported in brackets. Village population size, and ethnic composition, are drawn from the settlement location data. The Pashto-speaking population is winsorized at the ninety-ninth percentile and stated in per 10,000 terms. Total population along the road is added in column 5.

Attacks decrease voter turnout

	OLS turnout (1)	2SLS turnout (2)	2SLS turnout (3)	2SLS turnout (4)
<i>Panel A. Impact of morning attacks on voting</i>				
Attacks, 5–11 AM	−0.0107 (0.00651)	−0.0772 (0.0542)	−0.0921 (0.0482)	−0.145 (0.0607)
Election fixed effects	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Disrupted	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Surface winds		Yes	Yes	Yes
Rainfall		Yes	Yes	Yes
Temperature		Yes	Yes	Yes
Control squares			Yes	Yes
Preelec. winds				Yes
Observations	410	410	410	410
Clusters	205	205	205	205
K-P <i>F</i> -stat. (cluster robust)		7.261	10.62	10.57

(a) Effect of morning attacks

	OLS total votes (1)	2SLS total votes (2)	2SLS total votes (3)
<i>Panel A. Impact of IED deployment on voting</i>			
IED Deployment	80.78 (67.45) [75.23]	−5,078.5 (2,265.4) [4,293.8]	−7,434.7 (2,768.5) [5,056.7]
District fixed effects	Yes	Yes	Yes
Violence trend	6 Month	6 Month	6 Month
Rainfall			Yes
Observations	15,056	15,056	15,056
K-P <i>F</i> -stat. (robust)		12.07	12.28
Number of clusters	3,536	3,536	3,536
K-P <i>F</i> -stat. (cluster robust)		4.343	4.715
Weak IV robust <i>p</i> -value		0.157	0.0496

(b) Effect of IEDs

Discussion and takeaways

Counterfactual exercise to see how alternate violence would have changed outcomes

- 340-670 IEDs needed to tip election for favor of pro-Taliban parties
- Complete elimination of morning attacks → 12.3 % ↑ in voter turnout
- Additional patrol to 1 rotation per month from none → 5% ↓ Reported frustration

Takeaways

- Insurgents do compete for governance with the formal state
 - ▶ This includes other criminal actors like organized criminal groups
- Attackers do consider various trade-offs in committing political violence
 - ▶ Civilian support vs. Undermining state legitimacy
- Guidance on designing counterinsurgency efforts: When & where to invest in security

Dube, Naidu (2015):
Bases, Bullets, and Ballots: The Effect of US
Military Aid on Political Conflict in Colombia
[student presentation]

Takeaways and remaining questions

Politics, ethnicity, and institutions affect conflicts

- Ethnicity and other institutional backdrop create differing interests that lead to conflict
- Politics can propagate incentives to fight and provide opportunities for insurgents
- Overall, identity has been a driving force behind various conflicts

Unanswered questions

- What to prioritize: Rein in economic incentives or set up inclusive institutions?
 - ▶ Very complementary: One affects other and vice versa
 - ▶ Ongoing debate in the economics of institutions
- Individual participation in these activities?
 - ▶ We have mostly looked at effects of systematic economic incentives and institutions
 - ▶ For individuals, conflicts and crime are very costly. Yet why do they participate?